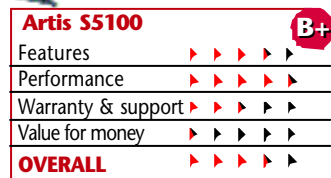


The Artis S5100 5.1 features good looks and very acceptable sound quality. The setup features true 5.1 surround support with discrete inputs for the front left, front right, center, rear left, rear right and subwoofer channels. The subwoofer



sonably priced at Rs 6,500.

The Artis S5100 left the other 5.1 speakers behind with its impressive sound quality for different audio effects. Background sound effects like the drag of a guitar, the double beat while a piano is being played, etc were reproduced with complete finesse. Coming in a close second was the Artis X8, which also exhibited impressive sound quality in reproducing these special effects and music tracks. In particular, it was able to clearly reproduce a detail that was missed by most speakers—the clunk of the shell falling after a cannon is fired. The Typhoon Acoustic 5.1 performed poorly in this test. Its effect was noisy and distorted, especially for loud sounds.

The Labtec Arena 530 took the crown among the 4.1 speakers by accurately reproducing the 30 Hz sound file and is therefore very suited to applications where you would want good bass frequency response as in R&B music or gaming. The Typhoon

Among the 5.1 speakers, the Mercury SR-301 F failed to play the 30 Hz file. Another speaker that had problems here was the Typhoon Acoustic 5.1. This speaker played the 30 Hz file but the sound was barely audible at the reference 50 per cent volume levels. As opposed to this, the Artis X8 played the same 30 Hz audio file with ease at the same volume level. The X8 displayed its strength in playing the other frequency bands too, where it played the test audio without distortion.

Power handling test: We played two MP3 files at maximum system and speaker volumes. Among the 2.1 speakers, the Labtec Pulse 325 played the ultimate bass and treble test file with surprising ease and there was hardly any perceptible distortion at high volume levels. Coming in a close second was the Sumoku Alpha - 4R with good response at high volume levels. The Typhoon DS1032 and the Mercury SW-480 suffered in this test. These speaker systems exhibited a high level of distortion when operated at high volume levels. When we played the ultimate bass test file, the overall sound quality started to get noisy even at 70 per cent overall volume tests—avoid these speakers if you like listening to music at very high volume levels.

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